Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

Will AI Replace Accountants?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

5.2

AI EXPOSURE · AUDIT / CPA ADVISORY

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open with a risk number, they either get frightened and shut down, or defensive about a decision they've already made.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation.

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And one thing specific to accounting. This profile has changed more in the last eighteen months than any other in the index — and not because of AI. The profession is in the middle of rewriting its own entry requirements, and a document written in 2024 would give your child materially wrong advice about how to qualify. Whatever you think you know about the route into accounting, check it.

The short answer

Accounting remains one of the more defensible business-family degrees — but only if the destination is the licence.

Audit and CPA advisory work scores **5.2** out of 10. Bookkeeping and transactional accounting scores **7.9**.

The CPA signature is a legal monopoly no software can hold. Everything below it is among the most automatable work we score, and much of it automated long before generative AI existed.

And there's a second story here that has nothing to do with technology: the profession is running a severe shortage and has just spent two years dismantling its own biggest barrier to entry.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Audit / CPA advisory	4.4	4.8	**5.2**	+0.8	Moderate
Tax advisory (complex)	4.8	5.2	**5.6**	+0.8	Moderate
Management accounting / controller	5.5	6.0	**6.3**	+0.8	Moderate–High
Routine tax preparation	6.1	6.6	**7.0**	+0.9	High
Bookkeeping / transactional	6.8	7.4	**7.9**	+1.1	High

Scores run 1–10, *where* 10 *is most at risk*. *For context: the median profession in this edition sits around* 5.5, *a business analyst scores* 7.6, *an entry finance analyst* 8.0, *and bedside nursing* 2.8.

Read the table this way — and note where it starts. Bookkeeping was already at 6.8 in 2023. Data entry, reconciliation and categorisation were among the first white-collar tasks automated anywhere, and that displacement is mature rather than emerging. What generative AI added was speed at the top of that curve, not the curve itself.

Why accounting scores the way it does — the six factors

Here's how audit and CPA advisory work answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A great deal — and accounting is unusual in scoring only moderately despite it.

Data entry and categorisation. Reconciliation and matching. Standard reporting and close processes. Routine tax return preparation. Workpaper assembly. Compliance checking against known rules. Audit sampling and testing.

We rate this **7.3**. What holds the overall score at 5.2 despite that is almost entirely regulatory protection and accountability — which makes accounting the clearest case in the index of a licence carrying a profession.

What resists: signing the audit opinion, judgment on an ambiguous accounting treatment, advising a business owner on what to actually do, and professional scepticism — knowing when the numbers are wrong.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Good, and getting better — which is almost unique in this index.

Two things protect it. The CPA pathway mandates supervised experience hours, so firms have an institutional reason to keep hiring and training juniors even where the work could be automated. And the profession is running a severe shortage: BLS projects more than **120,000 accounting and auditing openings annually** against roughly 55,000 graduates.

Section 5 covers the third thing, which is the profession actively widening its own door.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Almost none of it. Accounting is text and numbers in, judgments out. There is no physical component to protect it.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the licensed tier, absolutely.

An audit opinion is a statement a named professional stands behind, with personal and professional liability attached. Liability is a legal construct, not a technical one — no capability transfers it.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

For the audit signature, comprehensively — and section 4 explains why this licence works differently from law's.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

More than the stereotype suggests. Ambiguous treatments, unusual transactions, and the judgment call on whether something is materially misstated. Routine compliance work, by contrast, is the opposite.

The licence that also protects the training

This is the section worth carrying to other careers, because accounting's licence does something most don't.

Compare three professions.

Law reserves the courtroom appearance and the signed advice. It says nothing about who reads forty thousand documents — so when that work became automatable, nothing stopped it, and junior law now scores 7.9 with an entry-path rating of 9.5.

Nursing reserves clinical practice *and* mandates the supervised hours required to qualify. The on-ramp is protected by the same statute that protects the job, which is why nursing rates 2.0 on entry-path erosion.

Accounting sits between them, and closer to nursing than most people realise. The audit signature is a legal monopoly — a public company's financial statements must be signed by a licensed CPA, with liability attached. But the CPA pathway also requires supervised professional experience, which gives firms a structural reason to employ juniors regardless of what the technology can do.

That's why accounting rates **4.0** on entry-path erosion rather than business's 7.5 or junior law's 9.5. The on-ramp has narrowed. Licensure props it open.

The general lesson: ask what a licence reserves, and whether it reserves the training as well as the practice. Those are different protections, and for someone entering a field the second one matters more.

The thing that changed, and it isn't AI

Accounting has spent the last two years rewriting how people qualify, and it materially changes the advice.

For four decades, becoming a CPA required **150 credit hours** — effectively a fifth year of university beyond a standard bachelor's degree. Introduced in 1983 to raise the profession's standing, it became its biggest barrier to entry: an extra year of tuition, plus a year of foregone salary, at a moment when students were already weighing debt carefully.

The consequences were severe and are well documented. Accounting enrolments declined for over a decade. CPA exam participation fell to its lowest level since 2006. Roughly **300,000 accountants left the profession in five years**, and the AICPA/NASBA Trends Report shows a workforce increasingly concentrated in later-career age groups.

So the profession changed the rule. Around **43 states** have now altered or removed the 150-hour requirement, creating alternative pathways — commonly a standard bachelor's degree plus two years of supervised experience, rather than a fifth year of study plus one.

Why this matters more than it sounds. A profession that is deliberately widening its entry route, at the same moment most professions are narrowing theirs, is an unusual thing to find in this index. It is the entry-path factor moving in the opposite direction to everywhere else.

Two honest caveats. Legislative change is slow, and licensure numbers will take years to respond. And the reform doesn't touch the other reason students choose elsewhere, which is covered below.

The practical instruction: check the current requirements in the specific state or country where your child intends to qualify. They have probably changed since the last time you or their school looked.

What the trend shows

Audit / CPA advisory: 4.4 → 4.8 → 5.2. Up 0.8.

Bookkeeping: 6.8 → 7.4 → 7.9. Up 1.1, from an already elevated base.

The gap widened from 2.4 points to 2.7. What is distinctive here is how *early* the bottom of this profession was automated. Most careers in this index show a sharp change after 2023. Accounting's transactional tier was already substantially displaced before generative AI arrived, and this is the closest thing we have to a preview of what maturity looks like: not collapse, but a tier that quietly stopped being a career.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Regulatory / licensing	Strong and narrow	**Most durable**	The audit signature is statutory. But it reserves specific acts — unreserved work is unprotected.
Human trust / accountability	Strong at licensed tier	**Durable**	Someone must stand behind the opinion and carry liability.
Judgment under novelty	Moderate	**Eroding**	Ambiguous treatments resist; rule application does not.
Physical / embodied	**None**	n/a	Accounting has never had this.

The honest read. Accounting's protection is real, narrow, and entirely attached to the licence. The tier above it inherits some by proximity. The tier below it has none — which is why 5.2 and 7.9 sit in the same profession.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Entering and reconciling transactions	Already gone
Preparing the workpapers	Reviewing generated workpapers
Sampling and testing	Testing the full population, automatically
Preparing routine returns	Checking prepared returns
Learning the client by building their numbers	Learning them... some other way
Forming the opinion and signing it	**Unchanged**

Two things worth naming.

Audit is changing more fundamentally than the score suggests. When testing moves from a sample to the whole population, the auditor's job stops being "check a selection" and becomes "investigate the exceptions the system flagged." That is a more interesting job and a different skill.

And the training problem is real here too. Generations of accountants learned a client's business by assembling its numbers. That was tedious and it was also the education. The AICPA has begun work to redefine what early-career accountants need to know — which is a professional body formally acknowledging that its own entry-level competence has changed.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Professional scepticism** — knowing when the numbers are wrong, or when a plausible

> explanation isn't the true one. The most valuable and least automatable thing here.

2. **Accountability** — being the licensed human who signs. 3. **Judgment on ambiguity** — where the standard permits more than one treatment and someone

> has to choose.

4. **Advisory judgment** — telling a business owner what to actually do, not what the numbers say. 5. **Verification** — knowing when generated workpapers or a generated return are subtly wrong.

Notably absent: speed and accuracy of processing, and volume of transactions handled. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior and are entirely automated.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The shortage is severe, well documented, and works entirely in a new entrant's favour.

- **More than 120,000 annual openings** projected by BLS, against roughly 55,000 graduates
- Somewhere around **190,000–200,000 open accounting positions** at any given time
- Roughly 300,000 accountants left the profession in five years, and the remaining workforce skews late-career — meaning a retirement wave on top of an already-thin pipeline
- Starting salaries rising in response, with Robert Half projecting a further 3.7% increase into 2026
- The first real signal of recovery: a **12% increase in undergraduate accounting enrolment** in spring 2025

What accountants report as rewarding: genuine breadth of exposure to how businesses actually work, a qualification that travels internationally better than almost any other business credential, a clear and well-marked path to seniority, and — distinctively — that practice ownership is a realistic and common destination.

And the CPA is unusually portable. It opens finance leadership, advisory, forensic work, industry controllership and consultancy. Few credentials transfer this widely.

What's genuinely hard about it

The salary gap at entry is the profession's real problem, and it is the reason students choose elsewhere.

A first-year audit associate typically earns **$55,000–$70,000.** A first-year financial analyst earns **$75,000–$95,000.** A first-year software engineer earns **$90,000–$130,000.** These are the same students, from the same universities, and the gap has widened every year.

Busy season is real. January through April in tax and audit is genuinely punishing, every year, and it is the single most-cited reason people leave for industry roles.

The fifth-year cost, where it still applies. Where the 150-hour rule persists, the extra year carries $15,000–$50,000 in tuition plus a year of foregone salary.

And the perception problem is self-reinforcing. Students see accounting as rigid and stressful, which shrinks the pipeline, which increases the load on those who stay, which reinforces the perception.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Accounting tends to suit people who:

- **Are genuinely comfortable with detail** — not tolerant of it, comfortable in it
- **Like understanding how businesses work** from the inside
- **Are sceptical by temperament** — the professional core is not taking things at face value
- **Want a clear qualification and a marked path**, which accounting provides better than most business routes
- **Are willing to trade early salary for later optionality**

It's harder for people who:

- Want **high early earnings** — that comparison is the profession's weak point
- Need **variety over rhythm**; the annual cycle is fixed
- Find **detail work draining** rather than absorbing
- Dislike **seasonal intensity**

What else is moving this market

The pipeline crisis dominates everything, and it is demographic rather than technological. Every year of below-replacement graduates compounds it.

The 150-hour reform is the most significant structural change in the profession in forty years, and it is still working through state legislatures.

Offshoring is a real factor at the transactional tier and worth naming honestly — much of the work automation didn't take has moved rather than disappeared.

And there's a paradox worth sitting with. The shortage is severe and the entry tier is automating at the same time. Both are true because they are happening at different levels: the profession needs licensed CPAs badly and needs bookkeepers barely at all. A student who reads "accounting shortage" as a general green light has misread it.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: accounting is further into this than most professions. Audit software, automated reconciliation and AI-assisted tax preparation are established rather than emerging.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE ACCOUNTANT LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when generated workpapers or a prepared return are wrong. In audit this is professional scepticism applied to a machine rather than a client, and it is the same underlying skill.

2. Work with full-population testing. When you can test everything rather than sample, the job becomes investigating exceptions. That is a different and more interesting skill than the one accountancy training has historically built.

3. Advise rather than report. The reporting layer is automating; the "what should we do about this" layer is not. Every step toward advisory improves the score.

4. Understand the client's business. This used to arrive automatically from building their numbers. Now it has to be pursued deliberately — and it's what separates someone who can sign from someone who can only prepare.

5. Get to the licence. Everything in this profile points there. The pathway has just become shorter in many states; use that.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: check the current CPA requirements in the state or country where they intend to qualify. This has genuinely changed.

During: secure an internship — the profession recruits heavily through them and conversion rates are high given the shortage. Take audit and assurance seriously rather than treating them as the dull option; that's where the protection is.

Entering: public practice first, then industry if wanted. The reverse rarely works, and public practice is where the supervised hours and the licence come from.

The routes in

ROUTE	NOTES
Accounting degree → CPA	The standard route. Check current credit-hour requirements — they have changed in most states.
Bachelor's + two years' experience	The new pathway in many states, replacing the fifth year. Materially cheaper and faster.
Any degree + conversion	Common. Accounting accepts non-accounting graduates more readily than most professions.
Apprenticeship / school-leaver routes	Widely available outside the US and expanding. Paid, no tuition debt.
Management accounting qualifications	A different licence, industry-focused rather than public practice.

Where an accounting qualification can lead later

Unusually broad, and this is one of accounting's strongest arguments: public practice partnership, financial controllership and CFO tracks, advisory and transaction services, forensic accounting and investigation, internal audit and risk, tax specialism, industry finance leadership, and business ownership.

The pattern in this index holds: roles closer to the signature and to accountability score better. Management accounting sits at 6.3 rather than 5.2 precisely because nobody outside the business relies on it in the way they rely on an audit opinion.

What to look for in an accounting program

1. CPA pathway alignment — under the *current* rules. Does the programme map cleanly onto the licensure requirements in the state where they intend to qualify, as those rules now stand?

2. Internship placement rate and conversion. The profession recruits through internships. Ask what proportion secure one and what proportion convert.

3. Audit and assurance depth. This is where the regulatory protection lives. A programme light on audit is training for the exposed tier.

4. Does the curriculum teach data analytics and audit technology? Full-population testing is the future of the work.

5. CPA exam pass rates, and first-destination employers.

Questions to ask an accounting program

On licensure:

- How does your programme map to current CPA requirements in this state?
- Have your requirements changed in the last two years in response to the 150-hour reforms?
- What's your CPA exam pass rate?

On placement:

- What proportion of students complete an internship, and what's the conversion rate?
- Which firms recruit here?

On the curriculum:

- How much audit and assurance content is compulsory?
- How does the programme teach data analytics and audit technology?
- Where do students learn to review AI-prepared workpapers?

Red flags: vagueness about current licensure requirements; no internship pipeline; audit treated as optional; a curriculum unchanged since 2022.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Accountants and Auditors — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. Primary source and free: projected openings, wage distributions and entry requirements. The 120,000-plus annual openings figure comes from here.
- **Tracking CPA licensure paths: removing the 150-hour hurdle** — *CFO Dive*. The clearest account of the licensure reform: which states have moved, what the new pathways look like, and why the profession did it.
- **120 vs 150: understanding the new CPA licensure pathways** — the practical version of the same story: the three pathways as they now stand. Read this before assuming anything about how qualification works.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our score is demographic, and it is genuinely strong.
>
> Roughly 300,000 accountants left in five years. CPA exam participation is at its lowest since 2006. Openings outnumber graduates by more than two to one. On this reading, AI isn't displacing accountants — it is the only thing preventing a staffing crisis, and a score of 5.2 for the licensed tier badly understates how secure the work actually is.
>
> **Where we land:** we think this is right about the licensed tier and wrong about the tier below it, which is why we score tracks rather than professions. A shortage of *licensed* CPAs raises the value of the licensed path — exactly what this profile recommends. It does very little for bookkeeping and transactional work, where the retiring workforce is being replaced by software and offshoring rather than by people.
>
> **The specific thing we're watching:** whether graduate hiring at the large firms rises or falls as the 150-hour reforms take effect. If firms hire more juniors because the pathway is cheaper, our entry-path score comes down and we'll say so.

Bottom line

Accounting is one of the better business-family choices, and the licence is the whole argument.

The CPA signature is a legal monopoly, and unlike law's bar card, the pathway to it mandates supervised experience — which props open the on-ramp that most professions are losing.

The transactional tier beneath it is not a career any more, and hasn't been for longer than the AI conversation has existed. Bookkeeping scored 6.8 back in 2023.

And the most important recent change has nothing to do with technology. Around 43 states have altered or removed the 150-hour requirement, which is a profession deliberately widening its own door at exactly the moment most are narrowing. Anyone advising a student on accounting using pre-2025 assumptions is giving out-of-date information.

So the useful advice is: treat the licence as the product rather than the degree, check the current requirements where they intend to qualify, choose audit and assurance depth over general business content, and go into public practice first because that is where the hours and the signature come from.

And one honest thing to say to a student weighing this against finance or tech: the entry salary gap is real, it is substantial, and it is the profession's genuine weakness. What accounting offers in exchange is a licence, a shortage, and a door that is currently getting wider rather than narrower — which is a rarer combination than it sounds.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made accounting appealing? Push past "I'm good with numbers" to something specific. 2. Are they comfortable *in* detail, or just tolerant of it? Those are different, and only one sustains a career. 3. Do they want public practice or industry? Very different rhythms, and the order matters. 4. What does a Tuesday look like in the job they're imagining? What about a Tuesday in February?

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Audit and CPA advisory scores 5.2; bookkeeping 7.9. Does that change where they'd aim? 6. Bookkeeping was already at 6.8 in 2023 — before generative AI. Was that surprising? 7. The profile argues accounting's licence protects the *training* as well as the practice. Does that land?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. **The salary gap.** A first-year audit associate at $55–70K against a software engineer at $90–130K. Have you both looked at that squarely? 9. Busy season, January to April, every year. Have they pictured what that actually means? 10. **Have you checked the current CPA requirements where they'd qualify?** They've changed in most states, and this is the single most actionable thing in this document.

Part 2c — The other side

11. Of what accountants find rewarding — breadth, portability, a clear path, realistic ownership — which two matter most? 12. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then compare. 13. Are they sceptical by nature? Professional scepticism is the core skill and it's more temperament than training.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

14. Audit is moving from sampling to testing everything. Does that sound more interesting or less? 15. Accountants used to learn a client's business by building its numbers. If that's automated, how do they think they'd learn it instead?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

16. **The most valuable single action:** find someone three to five years into public practice and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that work still exists. 17. Can they get an internship or work experience at a firm? The profession recruits through them, and the shortage means access is easier than it's been in years.

Part 4 — About the program

18. Ask each programme the licensure-alignment questions from section 14. Vagueness here is disqualifying. 19. What's the internship placement and conversion rate? 20. How much compulsory audit and assurance content is there?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

21. If accounting weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals what they're drawn to. 22. Have they compared this properly against finance? Entry finance scores 8.0 against accounting's licensed 5.2 — the salary is better and the protection is worse. 23. Do they want *accounting*, or what accounting is made of — numbers, business understanding, a clear qualification, security? Those lead to different places.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

24. Am I recommending this because it sounds safe? Is that based on anything current? 25. Do I know how the CPA route actually works now, or am I working from what it was? 26. Am I comfortable with the early salary gap if the longer-term case is stronger? 27. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For accounting specifically, the licensure requirements described here are changing state by state — verify current rules before making any decision based on them.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Accounting

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

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Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-seven careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No licence exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

AUDIT / CPA ADVISORY — 5.2 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.9	6.9	**7.9**	2.77
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	**4.0**	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.5	9.5	**9.5**	0.05
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.3
				Total	**5.21 → 5.2**

TAX ADVISORY (COMPLEX) — 5.6 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.6	7.5	**8.5**	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	**4.4**	0.66
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.0	9.0	**9.0**	0.1
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.3
				Total	**5.61 → 5.6**

MANAGEMENT ACCOUNTING / CONTROLLER — 6.3 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	7.4	**8.0**	2.8
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	**5.5**	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	**7.0**	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.35
				Total	**6.3 → 6.3**

ROUTINE TAX PREPARATION — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.9	8.1	**9.1**	3.18
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.0	**6.5**	0.97
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.35
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.55
				Total	**7.01 → 7.0**

BOOKKEEPING / TRANSACTIONAL — 7.9 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.6	8.0	**9.2**	3.22
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	7.2	**7.8**	1.17
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	**1.5**	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.9
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	**3.0**	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.5	3.5	**3.5**	0.65
				Total	**7.92 → 7.9**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Audit / CPA advisory

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	5.9	3.2	1.85	**4.4**
2025	6.9	3.6	1.85	**4.8**
Fall 2026	7.9	4.0	1.85	**5.2**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.70** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.8** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labour market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

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7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.